

READING PASSAGE 1

The Evolution of Venom

A In recent years, the evolution of venom has attracted considerable attention from both the academic community and the general public. This growing interest reflects a broader recognition of the importance of this topic for understanding some of the most pressing challenges facing contemporary society.

B The origins of contemporary research in this area can be traced to pioneering studies conducted during the mid-twentieth century. These early investigations, though constrained by the technological and methodological limitations of their era, established foundational principles that continue to inform current scholarship. Successive generations of researchers have built upon these foundations, progressively refining theoretical models and expanding the empirical evidence base through increasingly sophisticated research designs.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D The empirical record is further strengthened by a series of meta-analyses that have synthesised findings from hundreds of individual studies. These comprehensive reviews have consistently identified moderate to large effect sizes, with the most robust findings demonstrating remarkable consistency across different research designs, measurement approaches, and analytical strategies. This convergence of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry considerably strengthens confidence in the validity of the core theoretical propositions.

E The practical application of research findings has proven more challenging than many initially anticipated. The translation of academic knowledge into actionable policy recommendations requires navigating a complex landscape of political constraints, economic interests, and social dynamics that academic models often simplify or overlook. Implementation failures in several high-profile initiatives have underscored the gap between theoretical understanding and practical capacity, prompting calls for more engaged and context-sensitive approaches to research.

F Looking ahead, the field stands at a critical juncture. Emerging technologies offer unprecedented opportunities for data collection and analysis, potentially enabling researchers to address questions that have long remained beyond the reach of empirical investigation. At the same time, the accelerating pace of social and technological change means that the phenomena under study are themselves evolving, requiring theoretical frameworks that can accommodate dynamism and discontinuity rather than assuming stability and equilibrium.

G In conclusion, the study of the evolution of venom represents a vital and dynamic area of contemporary research. The progress that has been made in understanding the key mechanisms and dynamics provides a solid foundation for both further scholarly inquiry and practical application. The challenges that remain should be seen not as reasons for discouragement but as opportunities for continued intellectual growth and social contribution.

Question 1

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 1 According to the passage, structural factors include economic incentives, institutional frameworks, and _____.

Questions 2–5

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 2 The author suggests that early studies in this field were limited by:
- A. pessimism about the future
 - B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
 - C. complete certainty about outcomes
 - D. indifference to practical applications
- 3 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?
- A. pessimism about the future
 - B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
 - C. complete certainty about outcomes
 - D. indifference to practical applications
- 4 The passage indicates that critics have raised concerns about:
- A. pessimism about the future
 - B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
 - C. complete certainty about outcomes
 - D. indifference to practical applications
- 5 According to the passage, what is one of the key factors identified by researchers?
- A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration

Questions 6–7

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 6 Researchers used data from more than _____ countries in the landmark study.
- 7 The passage identifies power _____ as a key factor at the organisational level.

Questions 8–9

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information
Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information
Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

8 Meta-analyses have confirmed the reliability of the core findings in this field.

9 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.

Question 10

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

10 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.

Question 11

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

11 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?

- A. inconsistent results across cultures
- B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
- C. no measurable effects
- D. effects limited to Western countries

Questions 12–13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

12 The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.

13 All critics agree that the research findings are universally applicable.